

Testimony of Commissioner Kimberly D. Geyer (Northwest Regional Hearing)

Good morning! My name is Kimberly D. Geyer and I am Vice Chairwoman of the Board of Butler County Commissioners. I appreciate the opportunity to speak at today's Northwest Regional Hearing on Congressional Redistricting.

According to the 2020 census, Butler County has added 9,901 inhabitants and now has 193,763 inhabitants. In 2010, Butler County had a population of 183,862, or a 5.4% growth rate. Butler County continues to be one of the fastest growing counties in Western Pennsylvania, if not the whole Commonwealth. All eight counties contiguous to Butler County have lost population in recent years. The only two counties other than Butler County with increasing populations in the Southwestern Pennsylvania Region are Washington and Allegheny Counties, which are both growing substantially slower with Butler County leading at a 9% growth rate. All other southwestern Pennsylvania counties including Fayette, Greene, Beaver, and Armstrong have suffered considerable population losses.

Butler County is technically classified by the County Code as a fourth class county and will remain to be classified as a fourth class county according to a population below 250,000. Butler County is the only county in the commonwealth that has consistent growth each year since its inception back in the 1800s. Butler County has fifty-seven municipalities, twenty-three boroughs, and eight public school districts among many parochial and private schools. Butler County is the only county in the commonwealth that has both a community college and a state university situate in the same county. Low taxes, affordable housing, job growth, low unemployment, good quality education institutions, and opportunities make Butler County a great place to raise a family, work, and live the American dream.

The 2020 census is the 10th census in a row in which Pennsylvania, as a whole, will have lost congressional seats. In 1910, Pennsylvania had 36 congressional seats and over time that figure has been reduced to only 17 congressional seats. Contrary to the principles instituted by a 2018 Supreme Court decision to keep all congressional districts "compact and contiguous" as a county, inclusive of all municipalities, and school districts, Butler County was broken into three congressional districts in 2018: the 15th District represented by Congressman Glenn "GT" Thompson, the 16th District represented by Congressman Mike Kelly, and the 17th District represented by Congressman Connor Lamb.

Today, I would like to provide you examples of how these multiple split congressional districts affects both our county government as well as residents who live and vote here. Butler County currently has 89 election precincts and 6 total Congressional splits within those 89 precincts. A part of Cranberry Township is carved out of southwest Butler County to make up the 17th District and is attached to Beaver and Allegheny Counties. Cranberry East 2, Cranberry East 3, Cranberry West 1, and Cranberry West 2 are split precincts represented by both Congressman Connor Lamb and Congressman Mike Kelly. Jefferson 1 and Jefferson 2 voting precincts are represented by both Congressman Mike Kelly and Congressman Glenn GT Thompson. Two of the split precincts have less than 20 voters. The Cranberry West 2 split has only 17 voters and the Jefferson 1 split has only 18 voters. Butler

County Election Bureau has to design and print two different regular ballots for each split precinct and design/print two sets of provisional ballots for each split. In addition, each split precinct must maintain two sets of poll books and design two reporting categories for each split for Election Night results. Each split precinct requires, audit materials as well as, poll worker education, poll worker training, and voter education. There has been confusion, as county officials have had to explain why one person could vote for one candidate while their neighbor located on the same street but three houses away, had different candidates on their ballot. Cranberry Township, Adams Township, Forward and Jackson Townships are situated in southern Butler County and are among the fastest growing townships in Butler County. One of the criteria for drawing congressional district maps is that districts must be of about equal size and cannot dilute the voter's voices based on race. Cranberry Township is likely one of the county's most diversely populated municipalities due to the transient nature of people who come and go from that area. This is due to employment related to global businesses associated with technology, healthcare, engineering, and manufacturing companies. Cranberry Township continues to grow due to its quality education institutions, low taxes, affordable housing, jobs, and proximity to nearby interstates, as well as, access to Pittsburgh and the Pennsylvania Southwestern region.

The 15th and 16th Congressional Districts were initially challenged by the 2018 split into two different congressional districts. However, because of the collaborative nature of both Congressmen, both being from the same political party, and both being professional and personal friends, their collaborative efforts to work together for the greater good of Butler County have served both districts in commendable ways. However, that is not to say, if you had two different congressional representatives and the dynamics were different, that would be the same case? Both congressional representatives in this case, are to be commended for making it work. The only two split precincts in the 15th and 16th congressional districts are with Jefferson 1 and Jefferson 2 in the Saxonburg area of Butler County. On a recent municipal leader's call, it was shared that many of our public do not know who their congressional representative is. Changing maps that change representation confuse residents and voters, especially when municipalities themselves are split such as Jefferson and Cranberry Townships.

From January-May 2021, Butler County had a bipartisan Election Commission of approximately 15 members study and review the election process in its entirety, to identify the strengths and weaknesses in the current Pennsylvania Election Code, the changes brought about because of Act 77, and Pennsylvania Department of State directives. The Butler County Election Commission then issued a comprehensive public report containing recommendations and made it available for elected officials, legislators, state associations, and the public. Butler County was the only county in the commonwealth's 67 counties to undergo this type of election review process and scrutiny. In regards to Congressional Redistricting, the Commission made the following two recommendations to the County Board of Elections. First, review precincts that have continuous turnout of less than 100 voters for possible consolidation with contiguous precincts to reduce the number of poll workers, equipment, and resources needed. The second recommendation is to be prepared to

respond to re-districting by adapting polling places so as not to have multiple Congressional Districts in the same precinct, and consistent with the laws of the Commonwealth.

Butler County Leadership work regionally with many surrounding counties, as partners, relative to economic development, transportation, workforce development, and emergency services. Butler County belongs to the Southwestern Pennsylvania Commission for regional transportation. Butler County belongs to the Tri-County Workforce Development Board with Armstrong and Indiana Counties. Butler County belongs to the Allegheny Conference relative to economic development from a regional perspective. Finally, Butler County belongs to Region 13 Task Force for Emergency Services that is made up of a consortium of counties. Regional partnerships cause counties to reach across into other counties to collaborate and work with other Congressmen on various issues and projects from a regional perspective. This can sometimes create challenges as well as opportunities for all involved. The best success stories are based on mutual respect, communication, and collaboration that ultimately benefit the taxpayers of the region overall. Lines on a map become less important when the focus is on accomplishing a project for the people you serve. At least, it should be!

In 2012, I testified in Harrisburg before the Pennsylvania Legislative Reapportionment Commission (PLRC) following the rejection of the first set of maps by the State Supreme Court. If you recall, because the set of maps were passed after the signature filing deadline, the 2012 elections were held using the old maps with the new maps going into effect for the 2014 elections. The 40th senatorial district, to which Butler County belonged to, went out to the eastern side of the commonwealth to Monroe and Northampton Counties and the 45th senatorial district went to McKeesport, Allegheny County. At that hearing nine years ago, I implored the committee to keep Cranberry Township completely intact and with Butler County. The PLRC did for the Senatorial map. Today, Butler County is requesting Cranberry Township to be contained with Congressional District 16 where it would be intact with surrounding municipalities. The old 12th congressional district became the new 17th congressional district in 2018 and this is where Cranberry Township has landed.

In closing, I appreciate the transparent redistricting process to date demonstrated by the Pennsylvania House State Government Committee. However, I conclude my testimony today with several challenges and an opportunity for you as committee members and elected state officials that I know would be appreciated by most of your constituents at large. Please allow Pennsylvanians an opportunity to submit draft ideas on maps, actually consider their points of view, and provide them an opportunity to hear why or why they would not work? (I recall Amanda Holt from Lehigh Valley providing various drafts of maps in the 2012 Pennsylvania Legislative Reapportionment Commission hearings that I attended.) In turn, when lawmakers design and draw their draft maps, please allow the people of Pennsylvania time to review them and have the opportunity to provide feedback to you. After all, this opportunity for both the committee and the people only comes once every ten years and it is crucial to ensure that every Pennsylvanian's voice can be heard as well as, be truly represented especially in a day and age when they often feel divided.

Thank you again for the opportunity to testify and share Butler County's perspectives.

Kimberly D. Geyer
Butler County Commissioner
Vice Chairman
August 18, 2021